

July 4 Is Always a Star-Spangled-Banner Day for Old Glory. Celebrate With These 15 Images of the American Flag

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An illuminated American flag display casts its colors onto passing cars, merging national symbolism with New York City's constant flow of people and light.

Yoshinori Sawa, New York, 2024

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Proudly hailed centuries and several iterations since its introduction, the American flag continues to be a symbol of unity and resilience for citizens of not only the nation but the world. Its 13 stripes represent the original colonies, and it bears a star for each of the 50 states. Songs and poems have been penned in its honor, and American flags—probably bleached white by the sun—are still planted on the moon. Whether waving atop government buildings, folded neatly at the tombs of soldiers or flying over a stadium as thousands of baseball fans sing its origin story, the stars-and-stripes stands as a symbol of what we aim to be. Take a look.

Tracy Scott Forson is a senior editor at Smithsonian magazine.

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